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VISIBILITY FOR MODEST CLOTHING STORE

Organic social media content posted on Instagram by customers impressed with its range of trendy tops for women is ensuring an enviable customer base for Rani Collection in Pondy Bazaar **P5**



10 YEARS OF SERVICE TO KIN OF WAR HEROES

Four war widows were honoured with financial assistance at the 43rd anniversary celebration of Humour Club International **P7**



Gen Z artists send out a message from Mada Square

On July 25, while Gen Z “cockroaches” grabbed the headlines from Jantar Mantar in Delhi, a bunch of artists from the same generation in Chennai were using their artworks to stir people’s conscience. The curator of the exhibition at Mada Square in Thiruvannamiyur, 18-year-old Samrutha SB on the why of it

LIFFY THOMAS

On July 25, when those supporting the protest launched by Cockroach Janata Party in New Delhi were rejoicing over the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as education minister, a teenager from Chennai was quietly assembling 11 aspiring artists whose craft is a commentary on systemic injustices.

Eighteen-year-old Samrutha SB is a student of BA Social Science at Azim Premji University in Bengaluru. In Chennai for her semester break, Samrutha decided to bring these artists with their works that open up avenues for conversations on fractures in social structures.

The trigger to do something to create a democratic space for dialogue and collective art stemmed from an experience she encountered in college and the recent protests that happened at various cities to show solidarity with the Cockroach Janata Party.

In February 2026, Azim Premji University was vandalised by ABVP members over an event organised by SPARK, an informal reading cir-



cle constituted by students of the University. Many students including Samrutha were witness to that chaos on campus.

“These event frustrated me on many fronts, but what disheartened me the most: one, the institution’s harsh actions against the wellbeing of its students and two, while most of us came together to question the administration, some students were fearful or apathetic,” says the resident of Neelankarai.

Samrutha felt like she needed to act on the frustration if she wanted to see change. “And art has always been my best companion at such times,” says the alumna of Chettinad Hari Shree Vidyalayam.

The public art exhibition showcased at Pagir on July 25 and Mada



▼ The group of artists; visitors taking in the artworks; and Samrutha SB

Square on July 26, both in Thiruvannamiyur, blended magic realism with themes of social justice.

Over four weeks, the artists, a majority of them students, engaged in discussions on art and political resistance, reflecting on their own social locations, questioning what distinguishes a system from a community, and grappling with the understanding that the personal is political.

These sessions were facilitated by resource persons which included Poorani C, founder, The Penn Collective; Venkataraghavan, author; and Anjana, a narrative art therapist.

The exhibition was timely. Like the protesters at Jantar Mantar that demanded accountability, the platform served to express dissent against social and political systems

of power and reimagine a more just world.

“I was happy to see people from all walks of life came to see the works. Art should be accessible for both visitors to view and for artists to exhibit, it should be relatable and most importantly it should come from a collective process,” she says. “My main aim was to politicise one another and ignite empathy for each other at this political moment through the discussion sessions as well as for the visitors. I wanted our artworks to be a response to everything we discussed and a seed for conversation that went beyond passive viewership. Conversations around caste, class, gender and the self grew in pockets next to each of the artworks throughout the two days of the exhibition.”

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45 schools take part in educators conclave

Sarvata Educational Consultancy organised the event at APL Global School

Sarvata Educational Consultancy, dedicated to the holistic development of schools and educators, held the Sarvata Educators Collective 2026 summit on July 25 at APL Global School. Over 45 schools and a vibrant community of school leaders and educators gathered to experience immersive workshops which focused on the human factor that no algorithm can replicate: moral and ethical discernment, emotional regulation, cognitive

empathy and conscious leadership. The theme - The Human Element, Thriving Alongside AI inspired participants to explore fresh perspectives on learning, leadership and meaningful human relationships in an increasingly tech-driven world.

The leaders and the teachers commented that the programme was an enriching experience and they learned strategies that can be implemented in their classrooms with the ongoing curriculum plan,

said a release.

Sarvata Educational Consultancy will soon launch the Sarvata Teaching and Learning Summit, a six-month interactive webinar series designed to support today's educators. The programme will take participants on a structured learning journey, beginning with the science of child development and progressing to pioneering active pedagogy.

For further details on upcoming programmes, call 91504 18101

FOMRRA partners with PLAN Foundation for composters

The Federation of OMR Resident Associations (FOMRRA) has partnered with PLAN Foundation to bring sustainable wet waste management to OMR. *The Hindu Downtown* dated July 26 had featured an article on the NGO providing free composters to bulk waste generators, gated communities being among them.

Rasiga Selvaganesan, assistant manager-project, PLAN Foundation, said the partnership will help them reach out to more communities on OMR. "We plan to provide aerobins to 72 bulk waste generators this financial year, and with more than 30 communities we have already signed an MoU. By collaborating

with FOMRRA, we will be able to identify more interested gated communities who are keen on on-site composting," says Rasiga.

Harsha Koda, co-founder, FOMRRA, in a communication shared with *The Hindu Downtown* said the Federation currently has five partnerships, this includes with Padcare for sanitary pad recycling, Spreco - for recyclable collection drives and Thinkgas - for piped gas in all homes. FOMRRA and PLAN are ready to expand this initiative to all OMR communities, adds the note.

To enrol your community, join the special purpose group at <https://plan.fomrra.org>

Talent hunt contest for persons with disabilities

DSW Trust along with Rotary Club of Centennial Madras is inviting persons with special needs for the second edition of its talent hunt competition. The pan-India event is exclusively for special needs children and persons with disabilities to showcase their talents on a bigger platform.

During the launch of the event held recently, the Trust urged the Government to fast-track UDID card issuance; provide priority allotment of Tamil Nadu Housing Board homes for persons with disabilities; increase employment opportunities in Government departments; provide employment preference for single parents of children with disabilities; and simplify the process for opening joint bank accounts for adults with disabilities and their parents/legal guardians.

For details, call 9043407150.

Registration: <https://forms.gle/QakRdE7JfY8n57rq9>

Reconstruct the broken walls

A broken wall has created an unauthorised passage for commuters near Guindy station

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of Bharathi Nagar and Race View Colony in Guindy have requested that Southern Railway reconstruct the broken walls along the railway lines in Old Narasingapuram, Race View Colony. This will prevent commuters and pedestrians from trespassing on to the railway tracks.

S. Raghavan, a senior citizen and a long-time resident of Bharathi Nagar, says, "Recently,



Southern Railway carried out a weeding exercise along the Colony, clearing bushes and the trees blocking the signal view. However, a few fell against the walls and eventually collapsed."

Since then, this has become a passage for commuters to board trains from the Guindy terminal and for pedestrians to reach Anna Salai.

"Recently, a young man from Bihar tried to cross the tracks, but was hit by a suburban train," said D. Manoharan, a resident of Race View Colony First Street.

The area is uneven, pitted and littered with garbage. The walls should be reconstructed to prevent further fatalities.

Commuters and pedestrians from Race Course Road and Chak-



The open passageway near the railway line at Race View Colony in Guindy. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

rapani Street, along Five Furlong Road, should walk through Narasingapuram First Cross Street, Maduvankarai, Race View Colony Main Road, Race View Colony Main Road Extension, Race View Colony Thiruvalluvar Street, Tank Street, and Bharathi Nagar, to go to the terminal and Anna Salai.

People from Race Course Road walking through platforms 3 and

4 and crossing the track to reach Race View Colony is a common sight. To go to Anna Salai, people cross the tracks and walk through Platform 1A.

Commuters from trains (towards Chennai Beach and Tambaram) cross the tracks, get on to platforms 3 and 4, and cross the track. To avoid taking a detour, people put their lives at risk.

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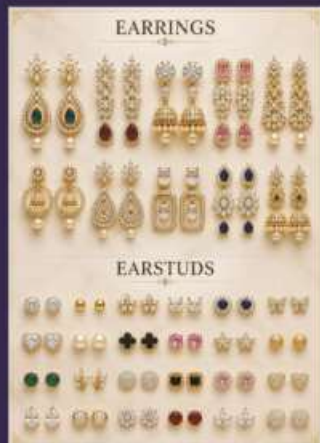
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Wear Your Style, Shine Every Day!

Gen Zers 'reel'

in visibility for modest clothing store

Organic social media content posted on Instagram by customers impressed with its range of trendy tops for women is ensuring an enviable customer base for Rani Collection in Pondy Bazaar, one extending beyond the Indian shores



Sikkander Sultan now; and an old photo of his shop in Pondy Bazaar that functions without a nameboard.

buyers' Instagram accounts.

Rani Collection run by Sikkander Sultan is nourished by healthy organic social media content, posted by customers on their Instagram pages impressed with its range of trendy tops for women and girls. Rani Collection operates from a small space within another store and for the convenience of its customers, a small part of it often spills on to a space under a tree without being underfoot. The sanctity of the pedestrian space is maintained.

Street Feed

A column about the quotidian on the streets of Chennai that finds itself in the spotlight on social media because residents took to it, and in cases involving a modest enterprise, customers were so impressed with its products that they drummed up a buzz around it through reels and posts

"Nearly 85 percent of our customers come through reels. Influencers visit us regularly, and that is how most of the people get to know about our shop," he says.

Gen Zers largely home in on this shop, and Sikkander himself is no spring chicken, being at least one generation removed. His family soaked in the garment business, Sikkander slid into the trade as effortlessly as one would through an open door, without any existential cogitations about purpose and calling. He established the shop at Pondy Bazaar in 2013, a good six years before pedestrianisation transformed the street into a congregating point, particularly for Gen Z. Sneakers-wearing Gen Zers now flit-

ting in, in good numbers, Rani Collection could not have kept Insta visibility off its racks even if it tried to. It draws shoppers from far beyond Chennai, much of that, says Sikkander, is thanks to Instagram. The reach however is not confined to the state. After spotting the store on Instagram, a customer travelling from Kolkata stopped by during their visit to Chennai. Others have walked in from Malaysia and Sri Lanka after watching viral reels, while some families in the United Kingdom and the United States often shop through relatives visiting Chennai. Depending on the size of the order, the store also ships internationally. Rani Collection offers trendy tops starting at ₹300, while complete sets are priced between ₹500 and ₹3000. Even a purchase as small as ₹300 can be exchanged, and the customer can be certain he would not be met with an irritated frown. As Sikkander puts it, "We want our customers to confidently wear what they buy."

If a garment is pushed to the back of a closet, it does injustice to the tailor who carefully stitched it. Every single thread reflects their hard work. I have seen their daily struggles, and I want their work to be valued." Beyond the bustling shop floor is a business man whose outlook is as contemporary as the collection he curates. He believes businesses must evolve with changing times, embracing new ideas and remaining relevant to a young demographic. Sikkander notes honesty and hard work are non-negotiables: open from 10:30 a.m to 10:30 p.m, seven days a week, "break" and "rest" sound like gibberish in Sikkander's ears. Without normalising workaholicism, one has to acknowledge this commitment just as one would this pavement store's rack strength and its owner's affordability. And Gen Zers are doing that with likes, reposts and reels on Instagram.

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

As the Pedestrian Plaza in Pondy Bazaar wears a twilight glow, young shoppers shuffle towards a modest clothing store near 'Crocs' store opposite Geetha Cafe. One shopper browses the displays, eyes peeled for that perfect dress,

and comes upon it, unfortunately, seconds too late. She eats her heart out watching it disappear into someone else's ravenous shopping bag. Friends hold up outfits for each other, debate colours and designs, and leave with a heavier bag, a lighter purse and a sprightlier step. Qualms written all over her face,

another shopper admits: "Here to keep a friend company while she shopped, I ended up with a shopping bag of my own. The seller's warmth won me over." On-the-spot reviews of this timbre do not dissipate but solidify into eWOM (electronic word of mouth), gaining permanence as reels and stories on

A singing circle spanning the city

Fuelled by Tamil music nostalgia, a community of amateur singers meet regularly across Chennai for singalongs. They are bound together by an organisation called Paadarivom Padipparivom which funnels its initiatives through an app

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Paadarivom Padipparivom traces its origins to the lockdowns of 2020. Former IT professional Naggeshwerran S., aged 43, known as NGR in the music community, noticed a pattern while scrolling through the Smule karaoke app.

"People were singing because they enjoyed it, but many of them were also being mocked online. We realised there were many people who wanted to sing but did not know where to learn," says Naggeshwerran.

A decision to do something about this led to free live sessions on Facebook and YouTube, where participants got to learn one Tamil song every week. The lessons were as simple as they can be: songs were broken down into simple sounds and rhythmic patterns. "I have been singing since 1992, but I never learnt Carnatic music. Friends would teach me using sounds instead of swaras. We thought if this method worked for me, it could work for others too," he says. The first session, held on May 4, 2020, drew close to 500 viewers, far exceeding the organisers' expectations. Requests for regular classes soon followed, leading to the formation of Paadarivom Padipparivom.

The community now operates from two studios –Madipakkam and Saligramam which serve as its primary spaces for learning and singing. Each studio can accommodate around 25-30 people and hosts regular singing classes, rehearsals, karaoke sessions and community singalongs. Members also gather there for Jam Along Vaanga, where they perform solo or duet songs before an audience.

As participation grew, the community began extending beyond its studios. An invitation from Cookgram restaurant in Anna Nagar led to regular singalong sessions at the venue on the first and third Friday of every month. The sessions, which combine music with a shared meal, accommodate around 65 to 70 participants and are consistently full. The group has since partnered with an event ve-



From singalong sessions organised by Paadarivom Padipparivom.

nue in Adyar for larger singalong sessions and has also received requests from a venue on OMR to host similar events. A majority of those who join are above the age of 30. "Most activities in music are designed for children or youngsters. We wanted to create something for people in their thirties, forties, fifties and beyond. Many of them are not looking for a career in music. They simply want a place where they can sing without being judged," says Naggeshwerran.

The organisation follows a structured cinema music curriculum rather than teaching only individual songs. Learners are introduced to concepts such as pitch, rhythm and expression through familiar film songs. Since 2020, the team has released lessons for nearly 300 Tamil film songs, each available on YouTube for learners to revisit.

As interest grew, the organisers realised members wanted opportunities to sing outside the classroom. This led to the launch of Jam Along Vaanga, a karaoke programme where participants perform solo or duet songs before an audience. "We call it 'Bathroom to

Green Room'. Many people only sing inside their homes. We wanted to create a path where they could first learn, then practise and finally perform before an audience," says Naggeshwerran.

The community now has around 3,000 members across WhatsApp groups, with participants from 26 countries joining both physical and online events.

An auction of singers

The group also organises Paattu Paarak, a singing competition inspired by the Indian Premier League. Participants are grouped into teams of six through a conceptual auction, without any exchange of money. Teams then compete in a cricket-style format, chasing each other's total scores across multiple rounds. The finals are organised as fundraising events, with the proceeds donated to charitable organisations. In the past two years, funds raised through the competition have been contributed to Akshaya Homes, a free residential home for destitute senior citizens.

Registrations for all events are managed through the group's PP Music mobile app. Participants can register, make payments and reserve slots for singalongs, competitions and other programmes through the app. Paadarivom Padipparivom has kept the registration fee for a singalong event at ₹299 to make it accessible to more people. Members with an annual subscription can attend events without paying separately, as the fee is included in their membership.

Beyond registrations, the app functions as a learning platform. Users can access free teaching videos, submit recordings of songs for feedback from mentors, and receive personalised comments on areas for improvement. It also features a "Voice Bank", where aspiring singers can store their recordings, a digital library of solo and duet lessons in Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Hindi for annual members, competition registrations, and a chat section that allows members to interact with one another.

For further details, contact 86680 18282 or @ppmusic0405 on Instagram



A singalong on wheels today

The Bus Singalong is Paadarivom Padipparivom's latest initiative. The Bus Singalong on August 2 with two routes across Chennai was initially planned with one bus for around 50 participants. When registrations opened through the group's mobile app, around 40 people signed up within one and a half hours. The response led to the addition of a second bus, taking the total registrations to around 85-90.

The bus sing-along event will take place from 3:00 p.m. to 8:00 p.m. Registrations have now closed, as the organisers have already received 90 registrations and booked two buses, which have reached full capacity.

Looking ahead, the organisers are exploring the possibility of hosting their next sing-along event aboard the Cordelia Cruise. While discussions are still in the preliminary stages, those interested can stay updated by following the group's Instagram page for future announcements and registration details.



▼ The dignitaries on stage and a section of the audience.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



LIFFY THOMAS

Humour Club International - Triplicane chapter made its 43rd anniversary special carrying forward a practice they started in 2016. For the 10th continuous year, the Club honoured four war widows, acknowledging their personal loss and supporting them with a financial assistance of ₹ one lakh each. In 2016, during an official visit to Srinagar, R. Sekharan, secretary of the Club, met some families who had lost their children protecting the borders. Their stories left a deep scar on him. Later, with the approval of the committee members of the Triplicane chapter they started to support families of war heroes financially. Instead of just crediting the amount to their accounts, the Club goes all out to reflect

10 years of service to kin of war heroes

Four war widows were honoured with financial assistance at the 43rd anniversary celebration of Humour Club International - Triplicane chapter

and honour the sacrifice war widows endure with a fitting tribute that was held this time at Kamaraj Arangam in Teynampet.

From one war widow in 2016, this time they had four of them who were honoured. In the last 10 years, close to 30 beneficiaries were identified.

Munvar Sultan, a retired banker and a member of the Club for

over two decades, says they seek the help of Anandham Youth Foundation and the Pensioners Association who forwards some of the most deserving applications for them to scrutinise.

“Every year, we select two war widows and a good amount of the financial assistance that we offer comes from the collection that we make during our month-

ly meetings. This time, two of our donors came on their own to support with the entire amount so we had four beneficiary in total,” says Sultan.

The families chosen are from Tamil Nadu and the Club sponsors their travel, stay and other expenses as a gesture of the sacrifice the ‘hero’ has made.

Started in 1983 with less than

15 members, the Triplicane chapter remains the most lively among humour clubs in the city. Their anniversary celebrations go to packed houses and is held at St Bede’s School auditorium and the monthly meetings draw more than 600 members.

Besides humour, the members have made this monthly outing meaningful adding a host of other social initiatives. They help Corporation workers and transgenders. “We give free grocery worth ₹ 2000 to the poor families and so far we have supported 185 families,” says Sekharan.

Milestone years of couples who are their members is another event they look forward to.

On August 9, the Club celebrates its 44th year at Mylapore Fine Arts Club at 4 p.m. For details, call Kannan, treasurer at 9841532212

Workshop on organic farming



Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on organic farming of vegetable crops on August 6. According to a press release, the session will focus on chemical-free methods of pest management, soil nourishment, and preparation of bio-manure. Participants will also learn about certification of organic products.

Another session on making soaps will be held on August 7. The programme is about making soaps from extracts of leaves, flowers, fruits, and herbs.

Both the session will be held at the centre’s premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048

One-year certificate course on entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, Guindy along with EDII - Ahmedabad is introducing a one-year certificate course on “Entrepreneurship and Innovation.” According to a press release, classes will start on August 3. Graduates from any discipline from 21 to 40 years of age can apply. To apply visit: <https://editn.in/Web-One-Year-Registration>
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Joining hands to champion disability inclusion



The Patrician College of Arts and Science in Adyar and Ruth S. Ammon College of Education and Health Sciences in New York hosted an international conference for individuals with disabilities.

Themed 'Empowerment Beyond Barriers: Global Perspectives on Education, Development and Innovation for Individuals with Disabilities', the conference brought together researchers, educators, policymakers, disability ad-

vocates, moderators, and participants from India and abroad to promote inclusive education, accessibility, innovation, and equal opportunities for persons with disabilities.

A major highlight of the confe-

rence was the inspiring cultural performances by more than 100 children with disabilities, celebrating inclusion through talent, creativity, and determination.

Lakshmi, I.A.S., Commissioner, Commissionerate for Welfare of the Disabled, Government of Tamil Nadu, inaugurated the conference.

Adding a unique cultural dimension, the conference featured a special screening of the documentary 'Swim', by Lara Stolman, a film and television producer and director. The documentary highlights powerful stories of resilience and inclusion.

The valedictory ceremony was graced by Gokul, I.A.S., Additional Collector (Development), Mayiladuthurai District, a visually impaired officer whose inspiring address reinforced the message that disability is no barrier to excellence and leadership.

An evening with Janaki amma

Musical tribute on August 9 will feature songs sung by the legendary playback singer



Samagratha Foundation is organising a musical tribute, 'Kaatril Undhan Geetham', in honour of the late legendary playback singer S. Janaki.

The concert will be held on August 9 at Vani Mahal at 5.30 p.m. and will feature the singer's timeless songs.

The event was originally conceived as a fundraiser. However, following the legendary singer's passing, the organisers have decided to conduct it as a free-entry tribute concert, ensuring the evening remains a sincere celebration of Amma's extraordinary musical legacy, said a release.

The programme will feature Janaki Amma's most memorable songs, presented by the singers of Samagratha, along with singers from Zee Tamil SaRiGaMaPa, accompanied by a live orchestra.

For details, call Vinod Venugopal, founder, Samagratha Foundation, at 98410 71971. WhatsApp 63817 88551 to know your nearest collection point.

What will Chennai look like in 2096?

At Yein Udaan's eighth annual day function, children from the dhobighat communities showcased this futuristic idea with a variety of performances



July 25 was a memorable day for more than 100 children from the dhobighat communities of Chetpet. At Yein Udaan's eighth annual day function, children presented 'Vanakkam Chennai 2096: A time travel story of hope' before an audience of 300 people at Shree Geetha Bhavan Trust in Gopalapuram.

The production provided a meaningful platform for children from an underserved urban community to showcase their talent, build confidence, and experience the joy of performing on a big stage.

Nawabzada Mohammed Asif Ali, Dewan and heir-apparent to the Prince of Arcot; Begum Seema Ahmed, a peace activist and a member of the Arcot Royal Family; and Revathi Sai Prakash, Director of Sairam Institutions, were the chief guests.

Seeing their children dressed in colourful costumes, performing with all their heart, and receiving applause from a large audience was a moment of pride for the parents, said a release.

The excitement of rehearsals, interactions with the producers,

wearing their costumes, seeing the stage transformed by the LED display, and finally performing and hearing the audience applaud made them feel like actors for one evening. In addition, they were dancers and storytellers, too.

The story explored the choices we make today and the world we leave behind, touching upon the importance of protecting our water, trees, soil, food and environment, while using technology responsibly and preserving human connection, the release said.

The celebration continued beyond the stage, with children enjoyed meals provided by Hot Breads.

Yein Udaan welcomes individuals, organisations and institutions interested in supporting children and communities through partnerships, volunteering and collaborative opportunities. Email: malavika@yeinudaan.org.

Medisoccy launches mobile applications

Medisoccy, a unit of Good Samaritan Health Care Services, has launched its mobile and web applications to drive the digital transformation of healthcare.

The event was held at VHS - M.A. Chidambaram College of Nursing, Taramani, and saw more than 250 healthcare professionals, nursing faculty and industry stakeholders.

Dr. Shankar Shanmugam, Registrar, Tamil Nadu Nurses and Midwifery Council, and Principal, Madras Medical College, was the chief guest.

Amalraj Ravi, founder and chairman of Medisoccy and Good Samaritan Health Care Services, said the applications have been developed with the vision of making quality healthcare more accessible, affordable, and patient-centric.

Medisoccy is a digital platform that removes intermediaries, allowing patients to choose their preferred providers while enabling professionals to work independently and flexibly, according to a release.

The services offered include doctor home visits, nursing care, physiotherapy, baby care, elder care, and tele consultation.

A range of services are offered like scheduling to book verified nurses, doctors, and therapists from home; professional medical care at the doorstep; transparent pricing; secure digital records; and an escalation and refund mechanism.

For details, log on to <http://www.medisoccy.com>

Call: 89394 94229, 89394 94239, 89394 94249, and 89394 94259

Challani opens store in Sembakkam

Challani Jewelry Mart has opened a jewellery store 'Lille' on Velachery Main Road. Tamil actress Dushara Vijayan inaugurated the store at Sembakkam in Selaiyur. Lille is designed for women aged 16 to 34. With a focus on minimalist and lightweight designs, the brand brings together elegance and affordability in every piece, from finely crafted earrings and pendants to elegant necklaces and bangles. Lille also offers men's bracelets, chains, and rings, and for children. The brand also showcases an exquisite diamond collection featuring rings, earrings, pendants, necklaces, and bangles, enhanced with beautiful stones such as turquoise, amethyst, sapphire, ruby, and emerald.

SIP NFO SWP

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